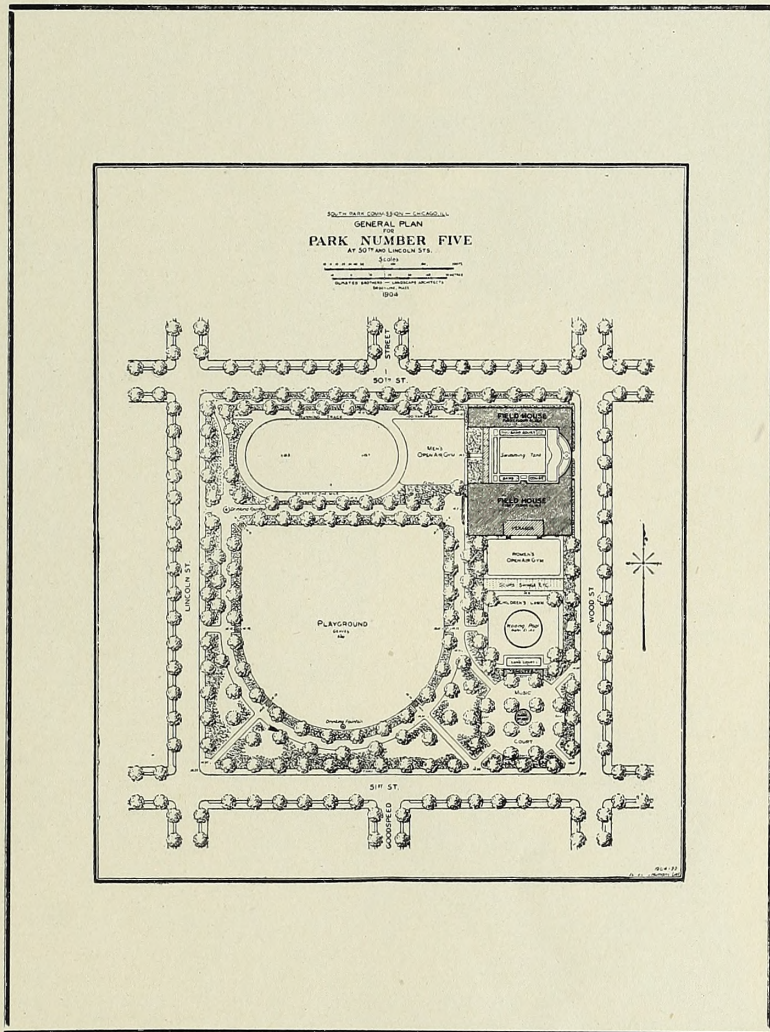


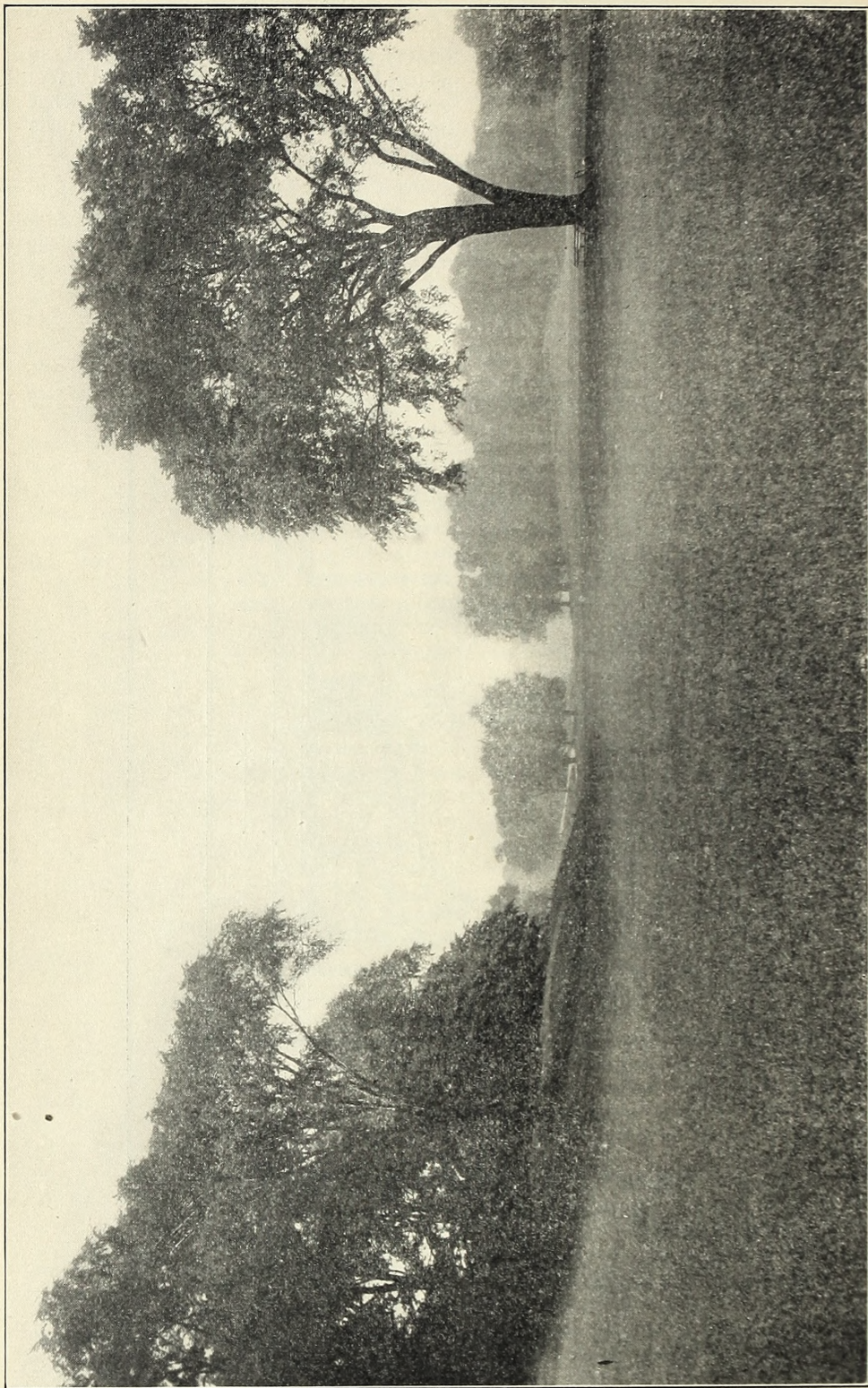
of the child, or maybe prevented that freedom of action which perhaps must be had to develop that individuality of character which makes the best of whatever there may be within us. And yet,

the day before had been so successful, so perfect in all its details, why should I feel there was something lacking, and what did that little girl mean by the words "real play."



The Modern Park-Playground.

One of a series of playgrounds for Chicago, Illinois. A typical plan to illustrate in a general way the features that are called for in a modern city playground and the manner in which the ground may be skilfully divided so as to make the best possible use of the space available. The design for every playground would normally be different, for no two sites nor the physical and human conditions surrounding them are exactly the same.



Prospect Park, Brooklyn. This picture illustrates the open parklike aspect of the Long Meadow,—the chief feature of the design. The extent of this meadow, about 50 acres, is enough to give it a sense of breadth. The surrounding groves are freely used for picnic parties.

The Normal Requirements of American Towns and Cities in Respect to Public Open Spaces

F. L. Olmsted, Jr. and John Nolen

[Mr. Olmsted is a fellow of the American Society of Landscape Architects and is the Charles Eliot Professor of Landscape Architecture at Harvard University. He is a son of the elder Olmsted whose genius planned Central, Riverside and Prospect Parks in New York, and also created the first city park system, namely that of Boston. Mr. Olmsted is a member of the distinguished commission appointed by President Roosevelt for the beautification of the District of Columbia, and has been retained as an expert in connection with much of the public park work of this country.]

[Mr. Nolen is a member of the American Society of Landscape Architects. His writings and lectures upon municipal improvement, landscape design and related topics have gone far to awaken intelligent interest in these subjects throughout the country. His public work has been largely along lines discussed in this paper.]

At the present time public spirited people in this country appreciate the value of open spaces in towns and cities. They realize that such areas are not only desirable but increasingly necessary in order that opportunity for exercise and for the enjoyment of outdoor beauty may be more generally provided. In a vague way they approve of a large increase in the number of playgrounds and parks. But few even in the more enlightened communities seem yet to understand that these open spaces are of great variety, that they are or should be selected and designed to serve radically different purposes and that the failure to understand this principle and to keep it constantly in mind leads to gross waste and inefficiency in our public grounds.

In few other phases of private or public life is there so generally a lack of clear thinking. This is an important matter for American municipalities to consider, for failure to select sites discriminatingly, to design them for specific purposes and to confine their use to those purposes, is to waste the public funds and to lose to a considerable degree the benefits that might otherwise accrue to the people.

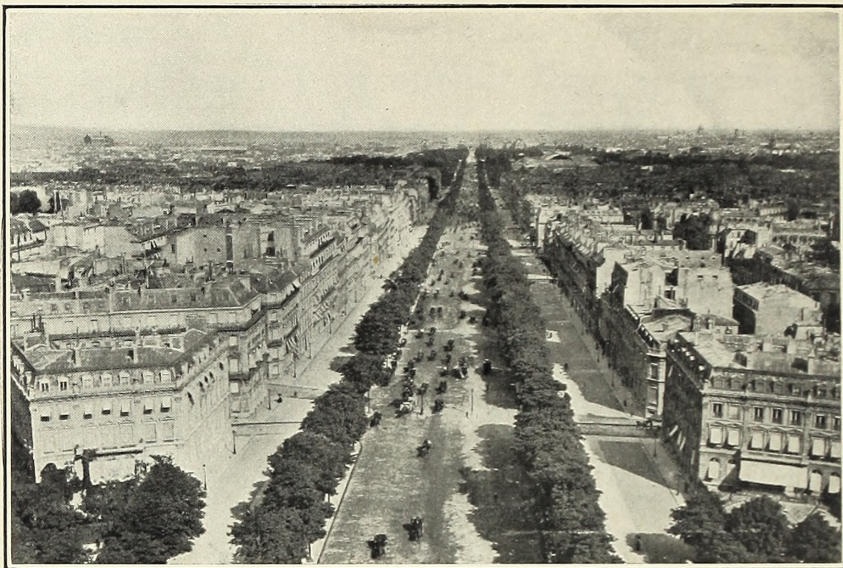
It is, of course, true in this as in most other matters that there is some overlapping. The purposes are not absolutely distinct and most public grounds are serviceable in a number of different ways. But it is equally true that the greatest efficiency here as elsewhere depends upon

clear and intelligent differentiation, upon a recognition that the ends to be served are different and that therefore different means must usually be employed to meet them.

This article aims only to outline in a general way the more important types of public grounds. For the sake of convenience and clearness they will be considered under six heads:

- (1) Streets, boulevards and parkways;
- (2) City squares, commons and public gardens;
- (3) Playgrounds—
 - (a) For little children;
 - (b) For children of the school age;
 - (c) For older boys and men and for girls and women;
- (4) Small or neighborhood parks;
- (5) Large parks;
- (6) Great outlying reservations.

These six divisions may be said to represent the normal requirements of large cities. For somewhat smaller places the outlying reservations and in some cases even the large parks might not be necessary. In such matters there can be no absolute rule. No system of public grounds could possibly be devised that would fit any and every community, for no two communities are alike. They represent infinite variations arising from differing physical, historical and social conditions. Success in any particular case will depend, therefore, not only upon a recognition of the different types of



Paris, Avenue des Champs Elysees: a formal example of a main artery of travel. Note separate provision of pleasure drive, shady promenades and side roads for traffic and house frontage.

public grounds but also upon an accurate and sympathetic estimate of the peculiar local conditions and local needs.

I. Streets, Boulevards and Parkways. All communities, no matter what their size may be, need to regard the plan, character and appearance of their streets. To do this intelligently, they must consider the primary purpose that streets in various parts of the town or city are to serve. For example, streets in the business sections would not normally be the same in width or treatment as in residential sections. Again, thoroughfares making through connections from one part of the city to another or even to outlying towns, would be different in many essential ways from streets that are intended for merely local use. This division of the subject, therefore, is fundamental and of practically universal concern. And proper consideration of it should affect definitely the city plan.

Boulevards and parkways are agreeable promenades in themselves and serve usually as pleasant means of access to parks from other parts of the city or from one park to another. Boulevards are usually arranged formally with rows of shade trees and parallel ways for

those on foot and on wheels. The simplest type has a broad drive in the center with a walk on either side, separated from the drive by a belt of turf and always shaded by trees. Frequently two drive-ways are provided with a broad space between containing trees and turf and sometimes foot paths, bicycle paths, bridle paths or other conveniences; and often shrubs, flowers, statues and other decorations. In recent years some boulevards have been made to provide for electric car tracks upon a special turfed reservation with rows of trees, where the cars can attain high speed with little danger of collision with other vehicles. Such reservations are generally between two roadways, but in some suburban districts a double track is placed on either side of a single roadway between the curb and sidewalk.

A parkway so far as it can be discriminated from a boulevard, includes more breadth of turf or planted ground and also usually narrow passages of natural scenery of varying widths, giving it a somewhat park-like character and inducing a less formal treatment of the roads, paths and accessory features. Parkway are frequently laid out along streams so

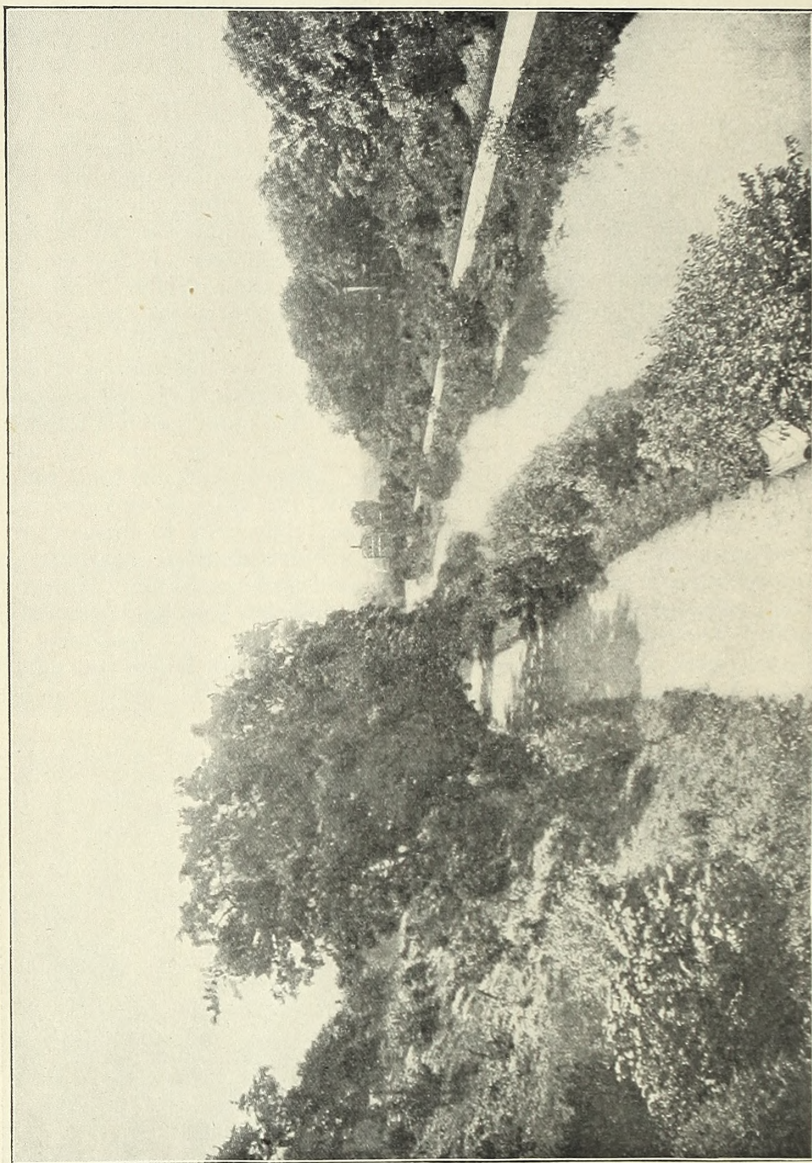
as to include the natural beauty of brook or river scenery and to preserve the main surface water channels in public control, thus providing for the adequate and economical regulation of storm drainage and floods. The illustrations herewith given will help to make clear this division of the subject.

II. City Squares, Commons and Public Gardens. These are a most usual type of public recreation grounds and often the most open to the charge of ill-considered selection and design. An opinion prevails very generally that a city can not have too many "squares" or "breathing places" and if they are not built upon and are green with grass and trees they justify themselves. In a measure this is true and yet by taking thought these same areas may be made many times more serviceable. They are usually of small size and are found in the business as well as the residential sections of a city. Their principal functions are to furnish agreeable views for those passing by them or through them in the course of their daily business and to provide a pleasant resting place or promenade for the much smaller number who take the time to use them in this manner. On account of the almost constant passing through such

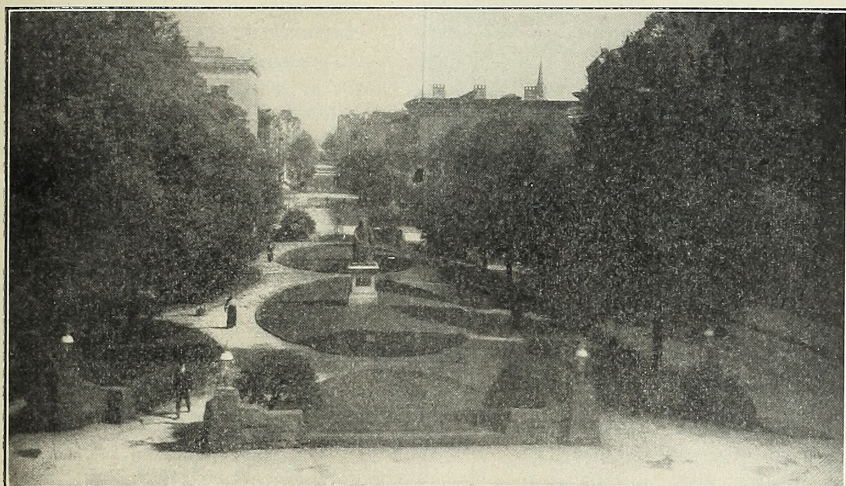
squares the best arrangement is to provide for reasonably direct and convenient paths along the lines most used. Where this is not done many of those who use the square are likely to be so irritated by the indirectness as to miss much of the pleasure they might otherwise receive. A formal plan of walks, either on straight lines or curved, is generally adopted for such squares and is well suited to the conditions and to the decorative treatment of the area, providing much more effectively than irregular plans for the numerous statues, fountains, and gay flower beds which have their most appropriate location in such places. Shade trees, either as a complete grove or in rows along the paths or grouped in some more complex plan, are almost essential features of such squares. A modification of this type of square is sometimes met with where the space, instead of being used for a short cut and for enjoyment from within, is designed primarily to present an agreeable picture to those passing upon the adjacent streets. When the area is very small and the passing is almost wholly along one side, this treatment is most effective, because where the only aim is a beautiful pictorial effect from a limited



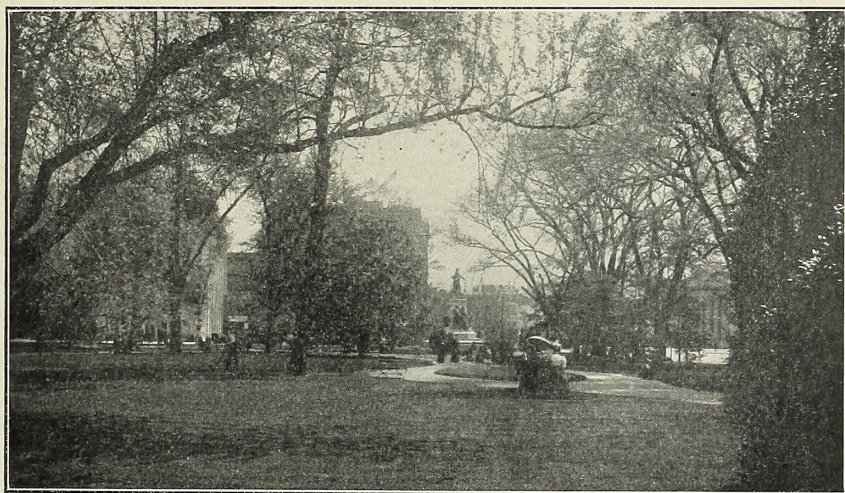
Vondel Park, Amsterdam. A narrow parkway serving to extend the scenery of a large park toward the city to a main thoroughfare.



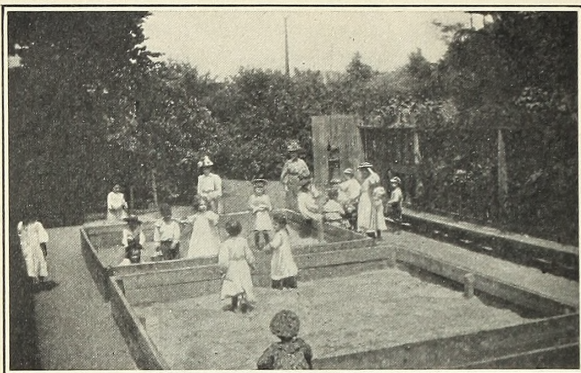
Riverway, Boston: A typical valley parkway maintaining a natural surface water channel. A railroad parallels the path at the right, but it is obscured by a mound of soil supporting a plantation.



Mt. Vernon Square, Baltimore, Maryland. A suggestive illustration of formal design well applied to a small open space in an American city.



Lafayette Square, Washington, D. C.



Charlesbank, Boston. The Sand Courts. Without doubt these are the most indispensable features in playgrounds intended for small children. The sand should be pure, white sea sand.

point of view better results can be obtained than when appearance must be reconciled with other uses of the land. Nevertheless, there are few cases in which a small square will not have a greater recreative value to the public if its pictorial aspect is somewhat sacrificed to such uses as resting and promenading. The illustrations here given of squares and public gardens will further enforce these points.

III. Play-grounds.

To no other form of public recreation grounds is so much attention now being directed as to playgrounds. An illustra-

tion of this fact is to be noted in the recent organization in Washington of the Playground Association of America. It has now come to be recognized that convenient provision for exercise in the open air is indispensable if we are to preserve health of body and mind. Indeed it is a matter of vital importance, calling more and more loudly for systematic municipal action as cities increase in size and density of population, as more and more people come to be engaged in confining occupations and as quick and cheap transportation

constantly reduces the amount of exercise which people take as an incident to their daily work. In a general way the imperative need for playgrounds is coming to be recognized especially as regards children whose development into healthy and useful members of the community depends quite as much upon physical as upon mental exercise.

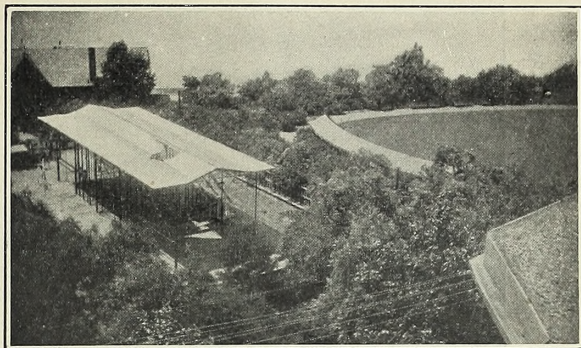
These playgrounds are of three classes. The first to be considered is for the smallest children. Whether in connection with school grounds or elsewhere, there should be in each neighborhood, a space not open to the hurly burly of the



Watertown, New York. Wading Pool. The definite provision of wading pools in playgrounds is comparatively recent. However, they have already proved themselves as popular as they are valuable.

larger children, where mothers may take little tots, mostly under the school age, to get quiet, out-of-door pleasure and exercise. A plain lawn, if well cared for, will stand their usage and is of the greatest value for them to play about upon. But for these youngsters even more than the older children it is needful to offer something to play with and nothing is more useful than a pile of clean sea sand. Its value is increased if water is near at hand to wade and dabble in. A small shallow basin in which they can play and paddle gives to hundreds of city children an amount of healthful pleasure that is cheaply bought at the price of setting apart such limited areas for their exclusive use.

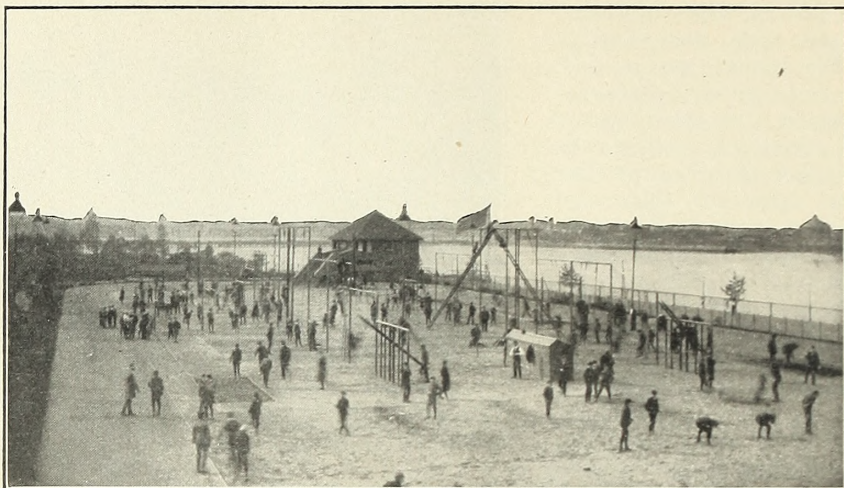
But perhaps the most important playgrounds are for the children of the school age and these can best be arranged and used in connection with the schools. Of course many schools have playgrounds but these are seldom large enough, for as school buildings have grown in size to meet the increasing demand, playgrounds have generally been encroached upon instead of being correspondingly enlarged. If it is agreed that it is almost as important for the city to provide adequate playground accommodations as it is to provide school rooms, there is need of very greatly increasing the present playground areas. A few large playgrounds in remote places where land is cheap will not answer the purpose, which is to give opportunity for exercise and active play near the children's homes, and preferably next to the school, so that it can be used during the recesses as well as after hours. Bare earth or some kind of pavement is the only surface that will stand the concentrated and constant use to which such a playground should be put, but that is no reason for making it an absolute Sahara of desolation. Trees will grow in such an area if adequate pains are taken to supply them with a quantity of good soil under the hard surface and to give their roots artificially the water which that surface cuts off.



Charlesbank, Boston. The Women's Gymnasium. The roof affords protection from sun and rain and the heavy planting of trees and shrubs makes the exercise ground private.

Vines on the buildings and a hedge or narrow border of attractive flowering shrubs, reducing the playing areas by a very small percentage, would often make the place more attractive to the children and give them some of the recreative value of beauty, which is cheaply purchased even at the cost of a few square feet of additional land. Moreover it can often be secured by the ingenious use of corners and strips that would be otherwise wasted. In this way the playground may be made an attractive and serviceable place to others besides the children and might be used by the elders in certain hours when not needed by the children. The devotion of much detailed ingenuity to getting the best possible use out of the city's investment in playground land is a corollary to the importance of providing adequate playgrounds.

The third class of playgrounds is for the older boys and young men, and for girls and women. As the city grows there is a constantly decreasing inducement or even opportunity for taking in the form of play the exercise which many of them fail to get in their daily work. For them are needed out door gymnasia and places for athletic sports. Unfortunately many of these sports require considerable area in proportion to the numbers engaged in them and for these the grounds must generally be at a greater distance from the people's homes than is reasonable for the other playgrounds. Moreover, some of these needs are cared for by private enterprise through clubs



Charlesbank Gymnasium, Boston. The first carefully designed and completely equipped outdoor gymnasium in the United States. It provides a space 500 ft. by 150 ft. for the use of men and boys and 370 ft. by 150 ft. as an exercise ground for women and girls. Happily combined with the Gymnasium are a level promenade nearly half a mile in length overlooking deep water and grassy mounds shaded by trees for the free use of little children.

and associations, and so far as this can be done it becomes unnecessary for the city to burden itself with the duty; but there are and always will be many who lack the means or the organizing power to secure such grounds for themselves, and the city can better afford to act as their agent and supply them with attractive grounds than to have them use their surplus energy in ways less useful to themselves and to the community. Grounds of this class should include ball fields, running tracks, places for jumping,

vaulting, throwing the hammer and quoits, bowling and the like, and convenient accommodations for bathing and dressing. The grounds should be ample, accessible, thoroughly complete in their arrangement and well maintained.

Here, then, we have three kinds of exercise so distinct as to call for three several kinds of grounds differing radically in size, distribution and arrangement although the apparently specific name of "playground" might be properly applied to each. The illustrations of the



Cambridge Field, Cambridge, Massachusetts. A playground with six acres of gravelled area. Designed primarily for the athletic recreation and education of the city's boys of school age. It is of course especially adapted for baseball and other games requiring a large space.

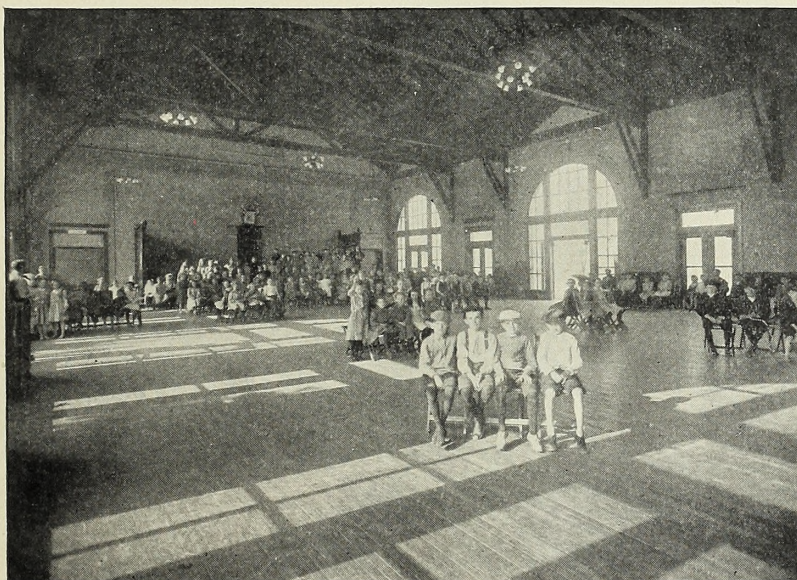


Courtesy City Parks Assn., Philadelphia.
Hamilton Park, Chicago. This shows a Neighborhood Center building. The construction throughout is of concrete. The central part contains the assembly hall, refectory and clubrooms. Each wing contains a gymnasium with locker rooms and shower baths with plunge. One is exclusively for men, the other for women. The wading pool is of ample proportions, and nothing delights the youngster more than to splash around in it and sail toy boats.

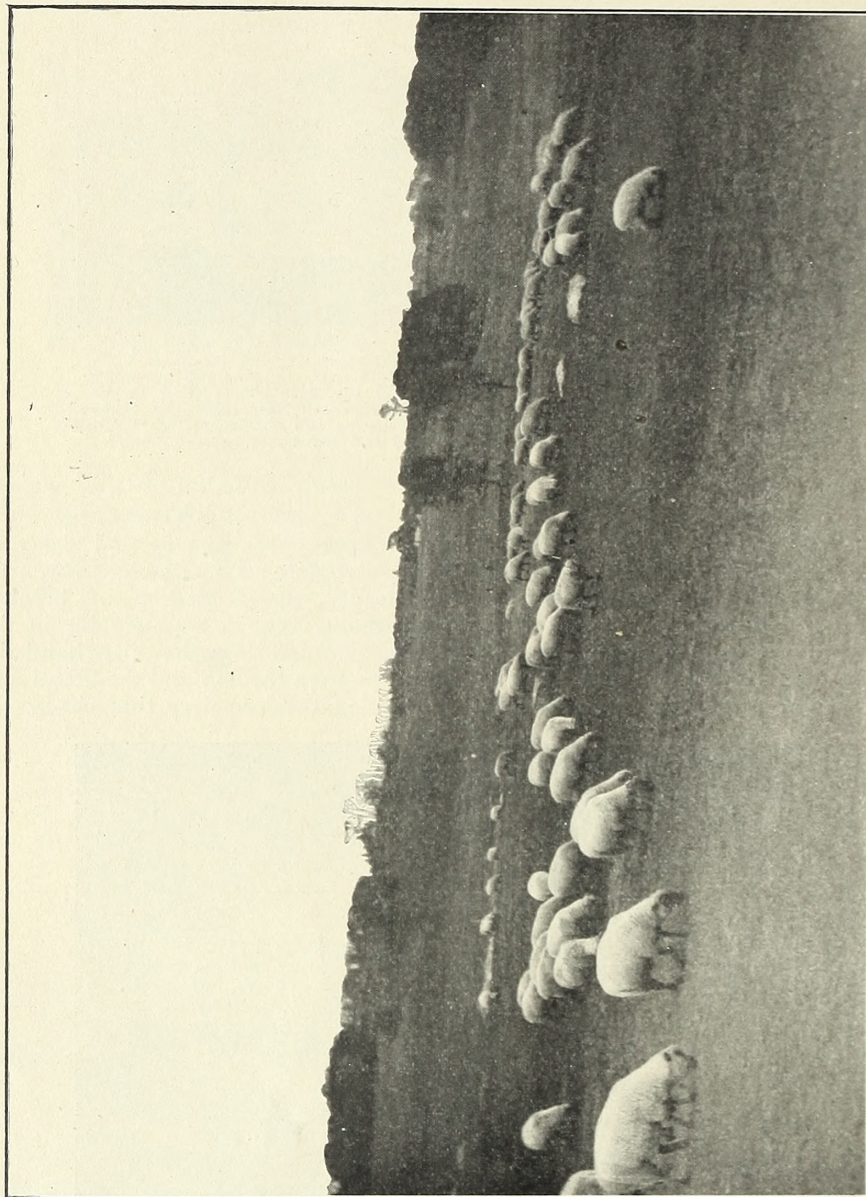
"Charlesbank," the first playground constructed in this country, and several of those in Chicago, will help to make clear the general character and usefulness of these grounds.

IV. Small or Neighborhood Parks. Under this heading may be included grounds of from 10 to 100 or even 200 acres in area. Except in extent such parks are

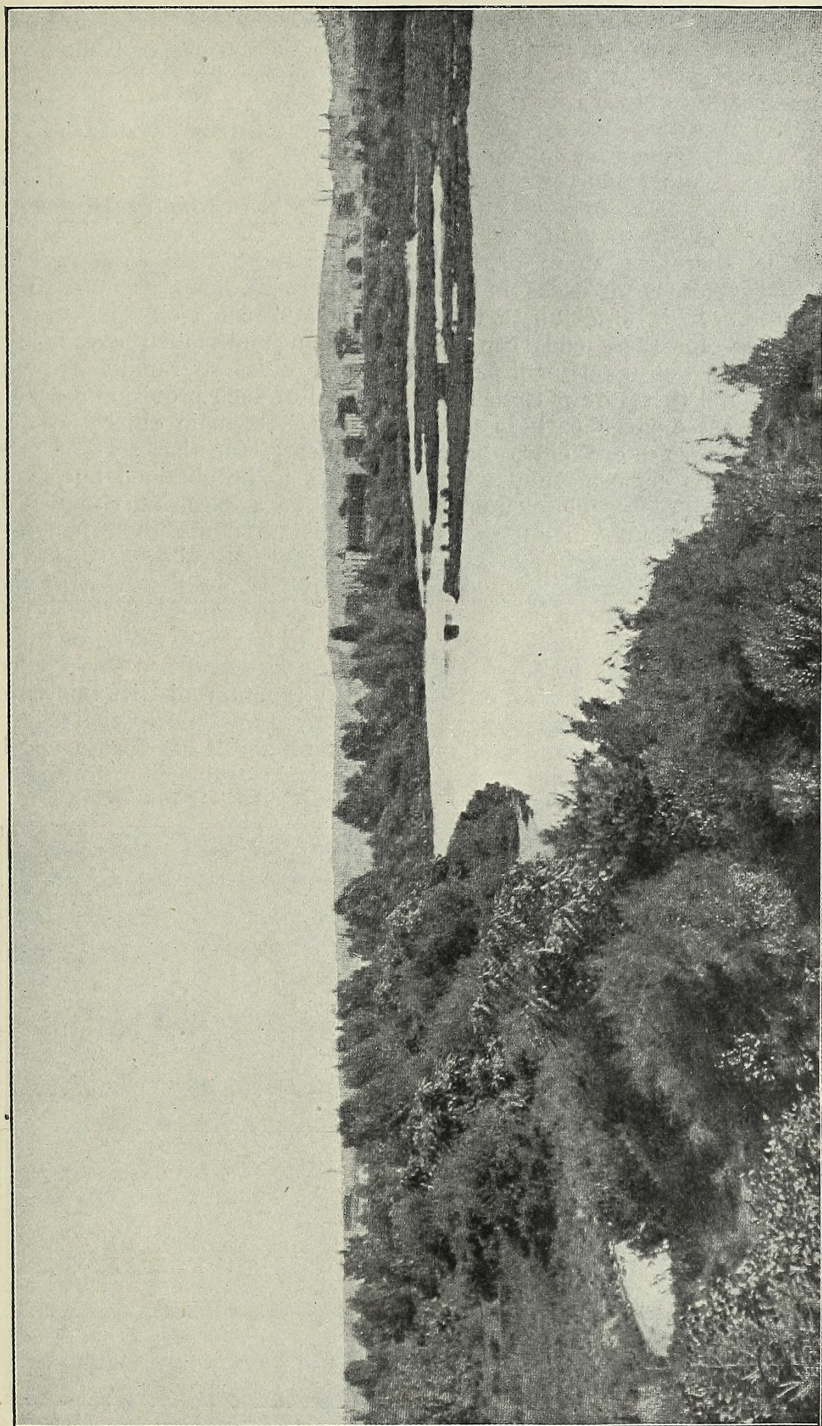
not essentially different in the purpose they serve and the character of their design from city squares and gardens. But this difference in extent affords an opportunity for a degree of breadth and freedom that is unobtainable in the smaller grounds. On the other hand the seclusion from the city and the broad and beautiful natural scenery that character-



Courtesy City Parks Assn., Philadelphia.
Mark White Square, Chicago. A typical neighborhood assembly hall. No charges made for its use, and only meetings of a political or religious nature are forbidden. Any person or group of people can secure it for an evening, provided some one else has not gotten ahead of them. Many social occasions and dances are given by neighborhood clubs.



Franklin Park, Boston. A typical country or rural park designed by Frederick Law Olmsted, Sr. The main purpose of this park is not amusement in the ordinary sense, but the relief from city sights and sounds that results from "pleasing rural scenery" (for complete account of Franklin Park see Mr. Nolen's article in *House and Garden* for July, 1906).



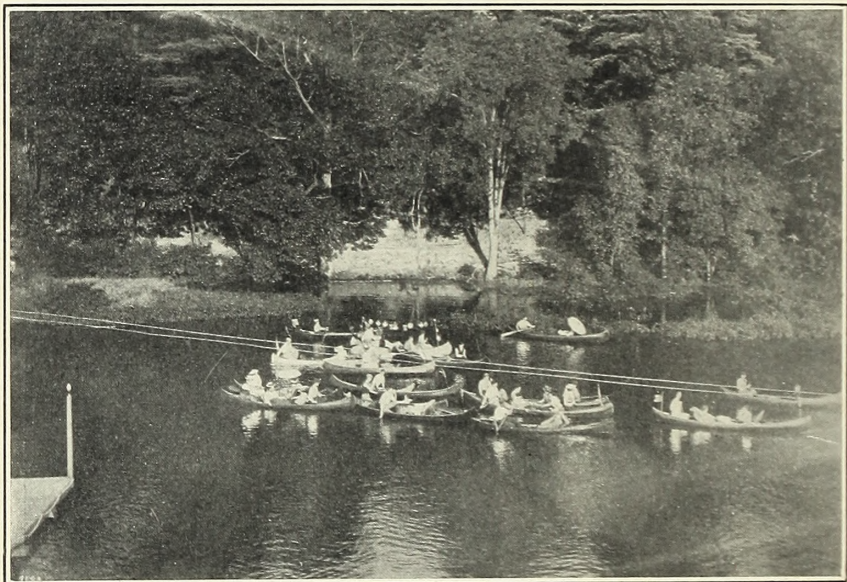
Back Bay Fens, Boston. Reclaimed flats converted into a landscape park in connection with solving an important surface drainage problem. A good illustration of the way a city may add legitimately to its income from real estate taxes.

ize the larger "rural" parks can not here be had. Yet small passages of interesting and agreeable scenery are often possible. This scenery can seldom be natural in appearance but it can often be quite beautiful, a certain elaboration, elegance and even magnificence taking the place of the more quiet and restful simplicity of the large park in a way that appeals very obviously to many people. And there is, therefore, more or less tendency to develop large parks in the same direction. It is unfortunate that it should be so, for these ends can be attained almost as well upon small parks as upon large, and therefore it is clearly a mistake to treat a large park in this style. It is because more cities have small parks of this elaborate and what might be called gardenesque character than have large and simple rural parks that many people have a perverted conception of what constitutes a park. These small parks are frequently used for the display of interesting and showy flowering shrubs and trees and make a feature of fountains, statues and other sculpture. In moderation such objects, together with terraces and other architectural work, are entirely appropriate and

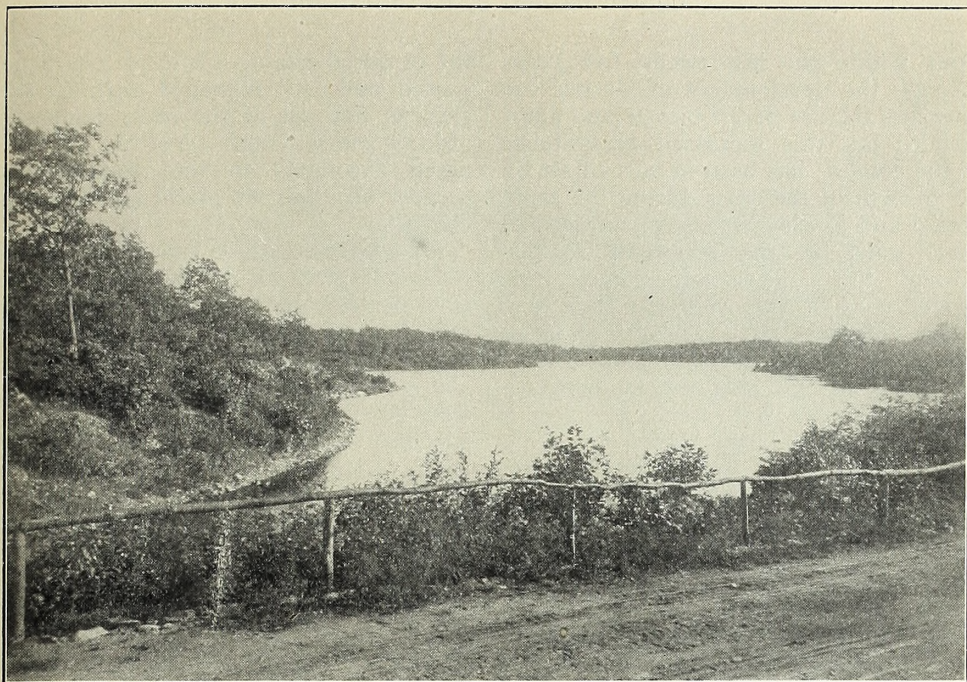
desirable in parks of this class and add much to the effect of elegance and richness, for the enjoyment is closely related to that offered by architecture and decorative design and other pleasures forming a part of daily city life.

V. Large Parks.

The large park, or the rural or country park as it is now generally designated, comprises in most cases from two hundred to a thousand acres or more and is the chief feature of a city park system. It is seldom undertaken except by large cities or cities so rapidly growing that the need of such provision can be clearly foreseen. Its main object is to provide conveniently for that sort of recreation which is to be obtained by strolling or driving in a pleasant country district. There is no doubt that the enjoyment of beautiful natural scenery is to the majority of city dwellers one of the most refreshing antidotes for the wearing influences of city life. Where cities are of moderate size and are surrounded by a beautiful country district this enjoyment is readily accessible to the mass of the population and it has fortunately become more so in proportion to the size of



Riverside, Boston. A popular boating resort under the control of the Metropolitan Park Commission. It is located ten miles from the centre of the city and affords wholesome recreation to thousands annually.



Middlesex Fells, Boston. A tract of forest containing about 2000 acres under the charge of the Metropolitan Park Commission. It is surrounded by the towns of Stoneham, Woburn, Winchester, Medford, Malden and Melrose. This reservation like all the other holdings of the Commission, excepting Revere Beach, has so far as possible been kept in its natural state. The pond scenery is of unusual beauty.

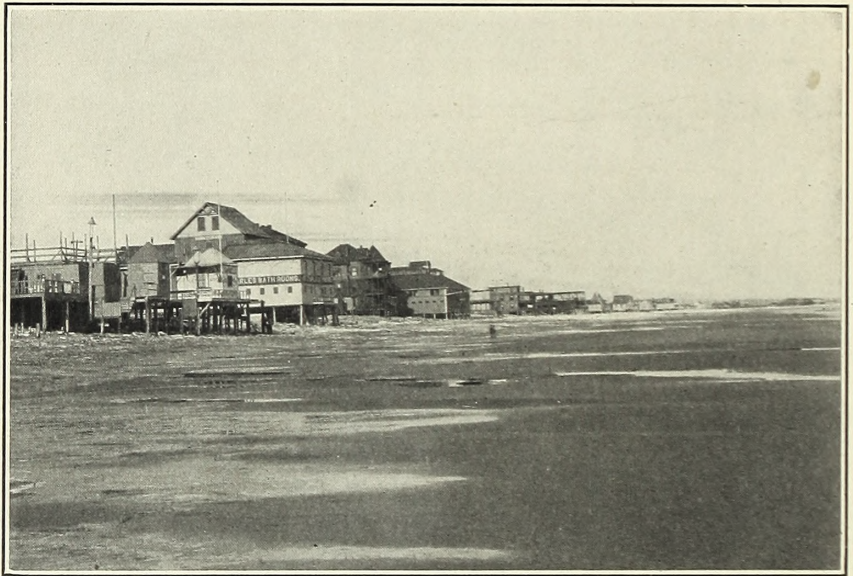


Blue Hills Reservation, Boston. Comprises about 3000 acres. It is an admirable illustration of the sort of property that should be secured for the public before urban and suburban developments make such action practically impossible.

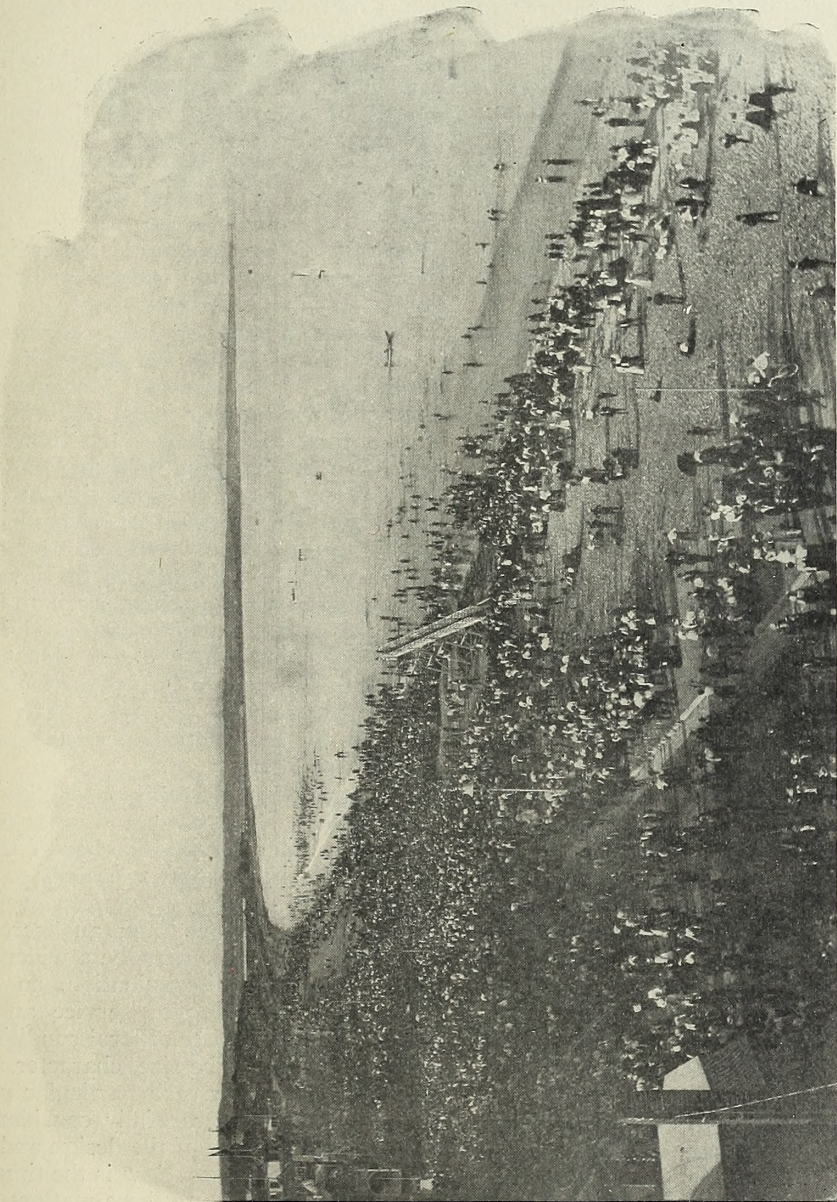
cities within the last twenty-five years through the development of electric car lines and the use of the bicycle and automobile; but this increased accessibility of the country has been in part offset by the growth of the cities during the same period and by the serious impairment of rural quiet in the suburban regions through the same cause,—namely, improved cheap transportation. It is necessary therefore, if the people of large cities are to have easy access to refreshing rural scenery that the municipality should withdraw from its taxable area a tract sufficiently large to provide some such scenery within its own limits. The cost, both directly in money and indirectly through interference with the street system and with the normal commercial development of the land, is necessarily very great, and only the purpose of providing beautiful scenery, of a kind thoroughly contrasting with city life and measurably sequestered from all its sights and sounds, can justify this heavy cost; because almost all the other purposes served in public recreation grounds can be met more economically and far more conveniently in smaller areas distributed throughout the city. Therefore,

the essential characteristic of a well designed and well managed park of this class is that all of the other numerous objects which it may serve are subordinated absolutely to the provision of scenery of a natural, placid and beautiful character.

Of course it is not enough merely to possess large areas of rural scenery, however perfect; they must be made available to large numbers of people, and it is the problem of making them available without destroying their most valuable quality that presents the greatest practical difficulty to the landscape architect. To turn the public loose upon them without restrictions and without the artificial appearance given by broad paths and roads, might be at the beginning delightful; but the marks of man's interference would soon be set upon the landscape far more universally and conspicuously by wear and tear than even by a number of constructed roads, and at the same time the inconvenience in getting about would interfere with the comfort of the visitor and his enjoyment of much of the landscape. Therefore, roads, paths, steps, bridges, seats, shelters, buildings and other constructions must nearly



Revere Beach, Boston. Under private control. Slatternly buildings encumbering the beach, and catering to a class which kept away the decent and orderly majority. Compare with illustration of Revere Beach under public control.



Revere Beach, Boston. Under public control. The shanties swept away, a broad promenade constructed, first class bathing facilities provided and good order maintained by an efficient park police. There is no more popular feature maintained under the control of the Boston Metropolitan Park Commission.

always be introduced. These can seldom be made to look like anything except the works of man and the disingenuous attempts occasionally made to palm some of them off as freaks of nature, in the way of curiously arranged ledges, grottoes, and what not, almost invariably seem so childish and affected as to be more obtrusive than a frank recognition of their man-made character. But on the other hand these things while treated frankly and simply as human constructions, may be made either relatively inconspicuous and subordinate elements of the landscape or may be elaborated into strikingly conspicuous features. In rural parks such conspicuousness is too heavy a price to pay even for great individual beauty in the features to which it may call attention, because it is essentially contradictory to the purpose of the parks. Architectural display is here to be deliberately eschewed. Of course beauty should be sought for in every element and detail of park construction but in the rural park it should be of the shy and modest sort which appears to be done not for its own sake, but solely for its contribution to the general effect. It should in no way invite public attention and admiration to itself.

Prospect Park, Brooklyn, containing five hundred and twenty-six acres, and Franklin Park, Boston, with about the same area, are useful illustrations of what large city parks may be. In neither, it is true, have the intentions of the designer been fully realized and yet the main idea,—the provision of beautiful, quiet scenery of the type that is called natural—has not been departed from. Therefore the "Long Meadow" of Prospect Park and the "Country Park" of Franklin Park can be studied with profit.

VI. Great Outlying Reservations.

As yet this class of reservations has not come at all generally into the possession of American municipalities. It consists of forests, beaches, meadows, mountains, lakes and rivers,—those natural features of universal interest and beauty that in one form or another surround so many of our cities. Such features are of

necessity great in extent but as they are almost always located at a considerable distance from the centers of population and are often ill-adapted to the requirements of trade and house building, they are not excessively costly. These reservations differ from "rural parks" in three particulars. They are usually located at a much greater distance from the centers of population, they are of larger area and as they are less used they require less in the way of artificial constructions. Their chief value is in the protection they afford for future generations; therefore, their preservation and possession by the public is of immense importance.

The most notable of such reservations in the United States are those in the possession of the Boston Metropolitan District including four forest reservations with a total area of over ten thousand acres also twenty-three miles of connecting parkway, seven or eight miles of seashore and thirty miles of river bank. But little more than a decade ago this system was non-existent and the invaluable reservations that comprise it to-day were the possession of private individuals, to do with as they would. The success of this system is an instructive and inspiring example of what can be achieved by enlightened, persistent and well-directed effort.

The conclusion that this paper aims to reach is that large towns and cities need not only to increase the number of their public grounds but more especially to increase their variety. A complex system is called for. More than an increase in expenditure, there must be a widening of aims, a finer discrimination, an expansion of the ideas of service and a more accurate estimate of local conditions and local needs. The size, character and location of sites for each particular purpose must be more carefully considered, as well as the nature of the design and its faithful maintenance. Now is the time to turn active attention to these matters for it is now that so many communities are moving to increase the number of their exercise and pleasure grounds. Energetic doing should be guided by clearer thinking.